

Campaign Brief: CMP-003 Winter Sun Early Bird 2025

Cymbal Voyages Brand Studio · Agency onboarding packet · Last updated September 2026

Flight dates: September 1, 2025 to October 31, 2025. Brief written August 2025.
Retrospective added November 2025.

Objective

Win back lapsed Cymbal Compass members ahead of the winter warm-escape season by getting them to book a warm escape for December through April travel before October 31, 2025. The campaign exists to turn members we have lost touch with into active members again while the booking season is still early and inventory is wide open.

Audience

Segment: `lapsed_compass` (Cymbal Compass members, any market, with no booking in 12 or more months), limited to cold-weather and mild markets. Warm markets are excluded because the warm-escape proposition does not land there. Size: about 10,000 members, of whom roughly 6,000 are in the eight cold-weather markets and 4,000 in mild markets. Propensity summary: median warm-escape propensity score of 0.14, with 12 percent of the audience at or above 0.30. This is a higher-propensity group than lapsed members as a whole because each of them has booked with us at least once and most of those bookings were warm escapes. Exclusions: members with an active reservation, members who unsubscribed from marketing email, and anyone who booked in the last 12 months (they belong to `active_compass`).

Insight

Lapsed members did not leave because they stopped wanting winter sun. Post-survey data from 2024 shows the most common reason for the gap was simply that no one reminded them at the right moment, and a smaller group had booked elsewhere once and found the experience impersonal. The Compass Anniversary and earlier points promotions tell us that points move members more than price does; a member who is offered bonus points reads the offer as being remembered, while a discount reads as a coupon that anyone could have found. The right moment is late summer, when the first cold mornings arrive in Chicago and Minneapolis and the December calendar is still empty.

Channels

Email is the primary reach channel and the most personal one. Three sends over the flight: a "Welcome back" opener in the first week of September, a mid-flight reminder around October 1, and a closing note in the last week of October that states the October 31 deadline once. Frequency cap: no more than two marketing sends per week to any member, and this campaign counts against it.

Paid social is the primary paid channel and the reminder layer, matched to the same 10,000 members. Frequency cap: three impressions per person per seven days. Direct (site and app) carries the offer on the Compass account page so that members who visit on their own see the same message. No paid search, organic, or affiliate activity is planned for this campaign.

Offer

Bonus points. Members who book a warm escape (any destination in the category, travel December 2025 through April 2026) between September 1 and October 31, 2025 receive 5,000 bonus Compass points, worth \$50 toward a future booking. Points post within 14

days of completed travel and follow standard Compass terms, including expiry after 24 months with no activity. There is no discount on the trip price. One creative test cell (see Creative direction) uses a 10 percent discount with a 72-hour reminder in place of the points offer so that we can measure the two framings against each other on this audience.

Budget and modeled reach

Total budget: \$180,000, all new money from the fall retention allocation. Paid social: \$122,000, at \$2,000 per day across 61 flight days. Production: 58,000, *covering creative production and photography licensing* (34,000), email build and landing pages (14,000) *and the post – campaign members survey* (10,000). Email media cost is carried by the standing CRM platform budget. Points liability is carried by the Compass reserve and is not campaign cost.

Modeled reach: email to roughly 15,400 deliverable addresses (96 percent of the audience) at three sends each. Paid social matched audience of about 10,900 members (68 percent match rate) and roughly 280,000 impressions over the flight under the frequency cap.

KPIs

Booking target: 1,500 confirmed warm-escape reservations from the audience by October 31, 2025, with a 30-day post-click attribution window for paid social and a 7-day post-open window for email. ROI target: 3.0 or better using the standard formula, (attributed revenue $\times$ 22 percent contribution margin – campaign cost) $\div$ campaign cost. Secondary measures: cost per booking under \$120, reactivation rate (bookers $\div$ audience) above 9 percent, and an email click rate above 4 percent on the opener.

Creative direction

Imagery: beach couple as the lead style, with resort aerial as a secondary test. Call to action: Plan your escape. Headline territory: "Welcome back" and the change of season, written to the reader's situation in a cold or mild market ("It has been a long summer of waiting for winter"). Tone note: warm, unhurried, no urgency language beyond stating the deadline once. Test plan, three cells of roughly 5,300 members each: (A) bonus points, beach-couple imagery, Plan your escape; (B) bonus points, resort-aerial imagery, Book now; (C) 10 percent off a warm escape, beach-couple imagery, Claim offer, with a 72-hour reminder in the closing send.

Legal review notes

Loyalty points disclaimer required on every asset that mentions bonus points, including the 14-day posting rule and the 24-month expiry. Price disclaimer required wherever a "from" price appears. Cell C copy must state the discount conditions and avoid banned urgency phrases ("last chance," "don't miss out"); "72 hours left" is permitted as a factual statement of the deadline. Imagery is licensed for paid and owned use through April 2026. Reviewer and sign-off date: to be completed at legal review.

Retrospective

Results. The campaign delivered 1,960 confirmed bookings against a target of 1,500, 31 percent over plan, on the full \$180,000 budget. Attributed revenue was about \$4.34 million, which at a 22 percent contribution margin gives an ROI of 4.3 against a target of 3.0. Cost per booking came in at \$92 against a \$120 ceiling. Reactivation rate was 19.4 percent of the 10,000-member audience. The email opener drew a 6.1 percent click rate.

What worked. The test settled a question we had been arguing about for two years. Cell A, bonus points with beach-couple imagery and a Plan your escape call to action, converted at 14.9 percent of its cell (795 bookings). Cell B, the same points offer with resort-aerial imagery and Book now, converted at 12.1 percent (645 bookings). Cell C, 10 percent off with urgency and Claim offer, converted worst at 9.7 percent (520 bookings),

and its bookers had the lowest average booking value of the three. Members told us in the post-campaign survey that the points "felt like recognition" and that a discount "would have felt like a coupon." The Welcome back framing outperformed a neutral subject line by a wide margin in the opener.

What did not. The resort-aerial imagery was handsome and it underperformed; lapsed members respond to people in the picture, not to property. Cell C's 72-hour reminder produced a small spike of bookings and a larger spike of unsubscribes, which we did not budget for and which cost us a portion of the audience for future campaigns. Paid social match rate landed at 68 percent, a little under the 72 percent we had modeled.

What we would do differently. Drop the discount cell entirely for Compass audiences; the question is answered. Lead with beach-couple imagery and Plan your escape for every lapsed-member campaign, and keep resort aerials for prospecting. Add the unsubscribe rate as a guarded metric on any reminder send. This retrospective is the source of the rule, now in the creative production standards, that percent-off and urgency framings are not used with Compass members.